

Bandit allyship: a theory of (imperial) co-optation

Abstract

With whom does the roving bandit ally? Existing research emphasizes the importance of exploiting domestic cleavages to exert control (Acemoglu et al., 2004; Padró i Miquel, 2007), but leaves open a series of strategic choices. Should the conqueror restore pre-conflict order by peacekeeping for the incumbent, or should it pursue sponsorship for the rebellion? Should it empower an ethnic minority or align itself with the majority? This paper develops a theory of foreign conquest that identifies the mechanisms shaping these choices. The baseline incentive of the emperor is to support aggrieved opposition groups. Only when domestic balance of power is featured by incumbent predominance does it favor the incumbent as the vassal. Having to pay the bureaucrats, as the most salient in Mongolian conquest, strongly favors allying with the incumbent in the later extension. The benchmark assumption of a relentlessly expansionist foreign also weakens once taken out of the political vacuum. Ideological, religious, or ethnic affinities can impose preference constraints that limit the pursuit of opportunistic conquest. The paper illustrates these two mechanisms by developing a benchmark model and a preference extension. The insight extracted from the model is applied to a brief discussion of episodes of historical conquests and rule.

Keywords: indirect rule, divide and rule, co-optation, colonial political economy, foreign intervention, formal theory

1 Two traditions

Be it coalition formation (Acemoglu et al., 2008) or rebel sponsorship (Salehyan et al., 2011; Di Lonardo et al., 2020; Qiu, 2022), war often involves three actors. The foreign, the incumbent, and the rebel. Sometimes foreign powers engage in “peacekeeping” and work to re-establish order for the incumbent; other times foreign sponsorship for the armed rebels emerges. When commitments to religion and ideology are taken out of the equation, and we look at the crude material structure, whose side should the foreign take?

Pivoting around these three actors, countless scholarly contributions have been made: interstate disputes can lead to foreign sponsorship of rebel groups, and civil wars can lead to externalization (Gleditsch et al., 2008). Extensive studies have been devoted to the internationalization of civil wars (Gleditsch et al., 2008; Findley and Teo, 2006; Johnson et al., 2024), the foreign sponsorship of rebel groups (Qiu, 2022; Di Lonardo et al., 2020), peace-keeping (Walter, 1997), and other related phenomena such as subsequent democratization (Gleditsch and Ward, 2006; Colaresi, 2014).

The key strategic dynamic lurking in these analyses is either a principal-agent problem of control (Bapat, 2012; Padró i Miquel and Yared, 2012) or a bilateral bargaining problem situated in the interstate level (Schultz, 2010; Qiu, 2022) or in a domestic level (Di Lonardo et al., 2020). The reason is that this line of work almost always assumes a sovereign order and shuts down the option of a durable presence from foreign powers in the target polity. Before the sovereign order, however, anarchy was more potent, and fluid state borders resulted. Foreign sponsorship for rebel or incumbent groups includes another menu option that was not contemporaneously available, that of indirect rule. Under indirect rule, the foreign power does not leave the target polity to their home but shares power with a local intermediary and stays. As a result, the three actors operate similarly to three “states”. Expanding Foreign’s action space by allowing power-sharing with the presence from Foreign, the paper applies the core dynamic of alliance formation from (Acemoglu et al., 2008) and the core intuition in (Salehyan et al., 2011) to address the “three-body” problem in a coalition style: under what specific conditions do foreign interveners ally with weaker, subordinate factions versus reinforcing the authority of dominant incumbents, or reign over parallel vassals?

One term that coins the phenomenon the model seeks to capture is an opportunistic war (Walt, 1996). Against the backdrop of domestic tension, a subordinate faction that is marginalized under the prevailing distribution of political spoils, possesses stronger incentives to accept external patronage. On the other hand, allying with the weaker party allows the foreign power to extract more favorable terms for power-sharing. Both the demand and supply sides point to opportunities for foreign powers to sponsor the aggrieved opposition. Numerous historical episodes, such as Mongol alliance with the Southern Song against the Jin dynasty, Spanish collaboration with Tlaxcala against the Aztec Empire, and British support for minority commercial interests in colonial entrepôts, support this conjecture.

Yet this expectation sits uneasily with a substantial body of evidence from African colonial history. French colonial administration in West Africa frequently reinforced the authority of existing paramount chiefs and traditional rulers (Crowder, 1964). British indirect rule in Northern Nigeria explicitly preserved and strengthened the Sokoto Caliphate’s institutional

apparatus (Lugard, 1922). In Buganda, the British collaborated with the established Kabaka despite the presence of subordinate groups amenable to external alliance (Mamdani, 1996). These patterns suggest that collaboration with dominant incumbents may, under certain conditions, constitute an equilibrium strategy.

This brings us to the second-closest term, popularized in colonial literature, namely Lugard (1922)’s handbook for “divide and rule”. [Literature here]

This paper develops a formal model that reunite the lurking logic behind both “divide-and-rule” and “opportunistic war” and reconciles these seemingly contradictory empirical patterns. The baseline model, analyzing a one-shot interaction between a foreign power and two domestic factions, confirms the first intuition: foreign actors almost always ally with the faction experiencing the greatest disjuncture between its coercive capacity and its share of the domestic status quo distribution. A “grievance condition”, as if, where the foreign power co-opts the aggrieved faction with a stronger incentive to overturn existing arrangements (Salehyan et al., 2011). When military predominance is overwhelming, however, siding with the incumbent is the right choice, especially if the incumbent already mobilizes a large group of bureaucrats to help extract resources in the target polity.

For a more theoretical note, one might benefit from interrogating the actual difference between coalition formation (Deutsch and Singer, 1964; Niou and Ordeshook, 1990; Acemoglu et al., 2008) and a two-level game (Putnam, 1988; Fearon, 1994; Schultz, 1998). We seemed to have always assumed a categorical difference between the critical mass as the domestic audience and another “state”. Looking at the dynamic through a coalition-formation lens is helpful because we no longer have to deal with the fact that the foreign has to leave upon victory under the sovereign-national order. Arguably, imperial co-optation and colonial control fill a “middle space” when there is no full-on anarchy, but the sovereign has not yet begun. Interrogating this middle place strikes one as particularly important, as it reveals dynamics that have evaded scholarly attention. The scenario in the middle captures a phenomenon in which the sponsee “state” does not evaporate and the sponsor state does not leave: they merge into a joint governing regime under the protocol of indirect rule. This intuition is captured in the final extension in the paper.

This first “economist” set of answers depends only on military strength and shares, free from all kinds of political constraints. The proliferation of equilibrium behavior that we do observe in history re-emerges once we admit that the factions differ in their political preferences. Adding a parameter of preference distance between the foreign power and each faction, equilibrium behavior dramatically proliferates. Political alignment accounts for off-equilibrium behavior from the benchmark prediction, such as unilateral invasion and

abstention. When no faction is close enough to be a reliable partner, ruling through a local stops paying, and the foreign power either brings in its own administration under direct rule or, when even that is not worth the cost of governing a foreign society, stays out.

2 Divide and rule: playbook for bandit allyship

One of the key puzzles in the grand scheme of African colonial rule is how amazing it is for small countries such as France and Britain to rule overseas and reign over a vast continent dozens of times the size of their homeland. [Historical analysis here]

2.1 Formalism

A war usually involves three actors: a foreign, an incumbent, and a rebel. We are going to situate the model in a predominantly historical context before the sovereign order, but the central dynamic can also apply to contemporaneous state sponsorship of rebel groups. The “unit of analysis” for the model is taxable income and collectible revenue. That is, parties are bargaining and contending over how to tax a mass of subjects that delivers raw production. The specification of the model is mathematically light and introduced with substantive prose below:

Environment

Imagine a game where an emperor F considers strategies over a target polity divided between two domestic factions; call these two factions D_1 and D_2 . Normalize the tax revenue collectible in this target polity as 1. Without loss of generality, the status quo allocates a share $s \in (0, 1)$ to D_1 and $1 - s$ to D_2 . For convenience, write $s_1 = s$ and $s_2 = 1 - s$. Since we typically expect the incumbent to have a larger share of domestic resources, for ease of interpretation, we could think of s_1 as the incumbent when $s > 1 - s$ and s_2 as the rebel; and vice versa. Each actor $i \in \{f, 1, 2\}$ is endowed with military capability, denoted by m_i . Conflict is governed by a contest success function $p(x, y) = \frac{x}{x+y}$, the probability that a force of size x defeats a force of size y . That means, if foreign wages a war against faction 1, she will have a winning chance denoted by $p(m_f, m_1) = \frac{m_f}{m_f + m_1}$.

Sequence of moves

1. F selects among three alternatives:
 - she could maintain the status quo and forgo intervention;

- she might opt to invade unilaterally, anticipating to wage a war against the unified domestic opposition. Because she forfeits collaboration, we assume that she will govern alone upon victory and penetrate the local polity with elites at home;
 - she might want to propose a co-optation arrangement $\tau = (\tau_1, \tau_2)$ specifying a tribute rate for each faction under indirect rule where τ_i is F 's share of the collected revenue from these local vassals. This option is straightforward in colonial times, but we can also think of a current arrangement, such as Akhmad Kadyrov's defection to Putin, as applicable.
2. If F proposes a deal in the last phase, D_1 and D_2 get to move in the sense that they simultaneously choose whether to cooperate with or resist F .
 3. Finally, we resolve any conflict that arises and payoffs for each party are realized.

Payoff structure

Under the status quo, payoffs are straightforwardly $(0, s, 1 - s)$ for foreign F , incumbent, and opposition.

Another rather straightforward scenario is if F , the foreign party, decides to wage war unilaterally. As such, F fights the two factions combined, wins with probability $p(m_f, m_1 + m_2)$. Upon victory, we introduce a lump-sum term for administrative burden κ_D , which is an inadvertent feature for ruling an alien society without local intermediaries; each belligerent must also pay a war cost $c_i > 0$. If the domestic "united front" is successful, the status quo is restored, and each faction retains its previous share of the revenue¹. Therefore, we could derive the payoff distribution as the following:

$$U_F(\text{Invade}) = p(m_f, m_1 + m_2)(1 - \kappa_D) - c_f \quad U_i(\text{Invade}) = U_j(\text{Invade}) = p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s_i - c_i \quad (1)$$

If there were a co-optation deal made, situations become slightly more complicated. First, consider the case where both factions cooperate. Since costly conflict is avoided and a viable protocol is established, F can install parallel vassals and get to collect $\tau_1 s + \tau_2(1 - s)$ for nothing but devising a credible threat. The remaining two factions get "robbed" willingly by retaining $(1 - \tau_i)s_i$ of the revenue collected.

$$U_F(\text{Co-opt}) = \tau_1 s + \tau_2(1 - s) \quad U_i(\text{Co-opt}) = (1 - \tau_i)s_i. \quad (2)$$

¹This is definitely a questionable assumption, but discussing the complicated scenario of a redistribution of power-sharing after the Foreign encounter exceeds the scope of this research note. Oftentimes, such re-negotiation depends on the idiosyncratic realization of war outcomes

The robbery may still result in full-fledged war when at least one of the faction resists. Without loss of generality, suppose the cooperating faction is D_i , and the newly formed coalition between Foreign and D_i can prevail with probability $p(m_f + m_i, m_j)$. Subsequently, victory for this newly formed coalition is an indirect rule arrangement under which Foreign governs through the surviving vassal. If, in the unlikely event, the stand-alone faction wins, it can seize the entire revenue collected without having to share. Incorporating the certainty equivalent of war, the ex ante distribution of payoff for each party can be written as the following:

$$\begin{aligned} U_F(\text{Defect}) &= p(m_f + m_i, m_j) \tau_i - c_f, \\ U_i(\text{Defect}) &= p(m_f + m_i, m_j)(1 - \tau_i) - c_i, \\ U_j(\text{Resist}) &= 1 - p(m_f + m_i, m_j) - c_j. \end{aligned}$$

Equilibrium There are two points worth noting before the math here. First, the core conjecture of the game is that Foreign is creating a prisoner's dilemma for the two domestic factions. Had one faction chosen to collaborate with the foreign, it is fairly easy to buy off another defection because you avoid the bleak prospect of an unlikely victory and the grave cost of a war.

But this model also deals with an additional question: what does the police prefer in a prisoner's dilemma? We always assume that mutual defection, and in our case, parallel vassals, is the ideal outcome that police would like to induce. But this assumption is sensitive to the division of power between the two criminals. We see many cases in the justice system where a plea deal is offered to secure convictions against the bigger fish. In our case, analogously, foreign sometimes work with the underdog to bring down the incumbent.

Lemma 1 (Domestic best responses). *Define the acceptance thresholds*

$$\tau_i^C \equiv 1 - \frac{p(m_i, m_f + m_j) - c_i}{s_i}, \quad \tau_i^R \equiv 1 - \frac{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f) s_i}{p(m_f + m_i, m_j)}.$$

D_i cooperates against a cooperating D_j iff $\tau_i \leq \tau_i^C$, and against a resisting D_j iff $\tau_i \leq \tau_i^R$.

Notice we don't straightforwardly have a clear relationship between τ_i^C and τ_i^R . Without loss of generality, observe that $\tau_1^R > \tau_1^C$ if and only if

$$s^2(m_f m_2 + 2m_1 m_2 + m_2^2) > (1 - s)^2(m_1 m_f + m_1^2)$$

In other words, which one is cheaper for Foreign is sensitive to the existing status quo

distribution of resources. This observation will be key to subsequent analysis.

Proposition 1. *Let*

$$\underline{s} \equiv p(m_1, m_2) - \frac{c_f + c_1 + c_2}{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)}, \quad \bar{s} \equiv p(m_1, m_2) + \frac{c_f + c_1 + c_2}{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)}.$$

If $s < \underline{s}$, F co-opts D_1 alone and fights D_2 ²; if $s > \bar{s}$, F co-opts D_2 alone and defeats D_1 ; if $s \in (\underline{s}, \bar{s})$, F installs dual vassalage at (τ_1^C, τ_2^C) .

We might call what selects the partner something close to a grievance formally defined by the gap between a faction's military weight, $p(m_1, m_2)$, and its share, s . When $s < \underline{s}$, D_1 is militarily rather strong compared to how little it extracts from the core revenue. Its outside option is poor, so it accepts a steep tribute, and F profits most by arming it against the incumbent. Ally with the strong but aggrieved challenger, against the established but militarily weaker holder of the status quo. Otherwise, a smooth, warless parallel vassal is installed. Figure 1 summarizes the three regions.

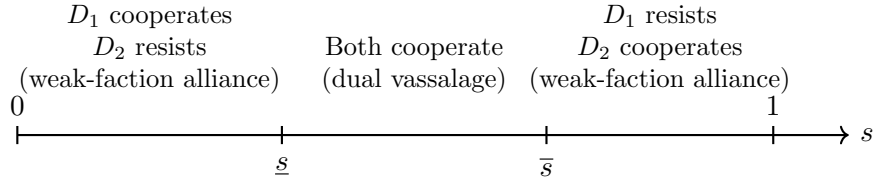


Figure 1: Foreign Power's Optimal Co-optation Strategy in One-Shot Game.

It is tempting to read the co-opted partner as always the smaller, aggrieved faction, the minority armed against the majority. That reading is mistaken. The co-opted faction holds share s in the lower region $s < \underline{s}$, and whether this share falls short of $\frac{1}{2}$ depends on where $\underline{s}$ sits. The next result pins it down.

Corollary 1. *The single faction the foreign co-opts holds a minority of the revenue, a share below $\frac{1}{2}$, in whichever extreme obtains, if and only if*

$$\left| p(m_1, m_2) - \frac{1}{2} \right| \leq \frac{c_f + c_1 + c_2}{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)},$$

which under $p(x, y) = x/(x + y)$ reduces to

$$|m_1 - m_2| \leq 2(c_f + c_1 + c_2)(m_1 + m_2 + m_f).$$

²Perhaps by offering a deal that cannot be accepted such that $\tau_2 > \max\{\tau_2^C, \tau_2^R\}$

If the military gap exceeds this bound, the foreign instead co-opts the militarily dominant faction over a range where it already commands the majority.

So whether the foreign empowers a minority or sides with the majority is not a matter of taste but of the military balance set against the cost of war. When the two factions are militarily close, $m_1 \approx m_2$, the gap is small and the condition holds: the foreign co-opts only where its partner is a resented minority, the classic divide-and-rule alliance with the aggrieved. When one faction is militarily dominant, $m_1 \gg m_2$, the condition fails: the foreign throws in with the strong, even where the strong already hold most of the country because empowering the minority is just too costly here.

Figure 2 demonstrates these new regions in Proposition 1, which is different from Figure 1 in the sense that $\frac{1}{2} \notin (\underline{s}, \bar{s})$. ($s < \frac{1}{2}$) from those in which D_1 is the incumbent ($s > \frac{1}{2}$). Panel (a) is the case $\underline{s} > \frac{1}{2}$, where D_1 is militarily dominant: the foreign collaborates with the opposition on $[0, \frac{1}{2})$ and on $(\bar{s}, 1]$, but with the incumbent on $[\frac{1}{2}, \underline{s})$. Panel (b) is the mirror case $\bar{s} < \frac{1}{2}$, where D_2 is militarily dominant: collaboration runs with the opposition on $[0, \underline{s})$ and on $[\frac{1}{2}, 1]$, and with the incumbent on $(\bar{s}, \frac{1}{2})$. In the symmetric remainder, $\underline{s} \leq \frac{1}{2} \leq \bar{s}$, both cutoffs sit on the same side of $\frac{1}{2}$ as in Figure 1 and the co-opted partner is the opposition throughout.

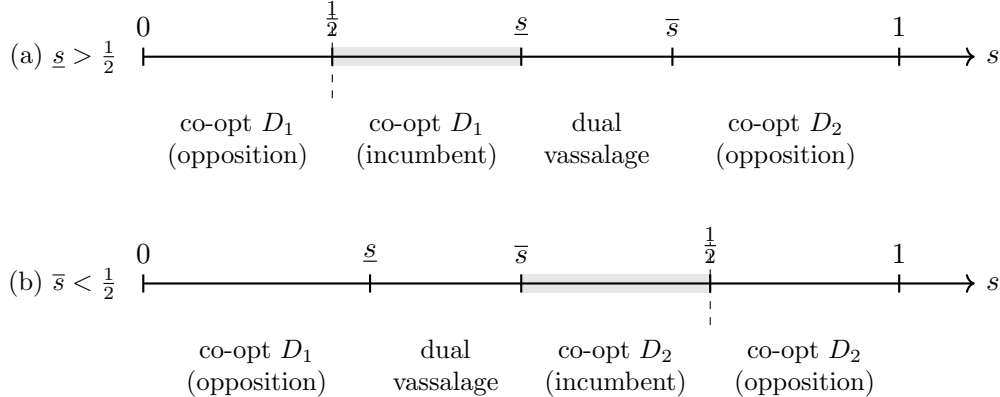


Figure 2: Incumbent versus opposition partner when a cutoff crosses $s = \frac{1}{2}$. The dashed line marks $s = \frac{1}{2}$; left of it D_1 is the opposition, right of it D_1 is the incumbent. The foreign collaborates with the incumbent only in the shaded sliver between $\frac{1}{2}$ and the boundary cutoff, and with the opposition elsewhere.

Proposition 2 (Conquest is never strictly preferred). *For all parameter values, F does not strictly prefer unilateral invasion to co-optation.*

Because establishing parallel vassals is always available, which yields F a payoff of $p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) + c_1 + c_2$, unilateral invasion, which yields $p(m_f, m_1 + m_2)(1 - \kappa_D) - c_f$, is

always strictly dominated. Direct rule pays the governance cost κ_D and forfeits the war costs c_1, c_2 that resistance would otherwise impose on the factions. We can think of this as co-optation lets the conqueror offload the burden of governing onto locals while still extracting tribute. It's a sweet robbery compared to having to bite alone.

3 Onward and upward: who eats whom tomorrow

The benchmark assumed a winning vassal honors the tribute it agreed to. A partner that wins the war and then rules alone, however, is no longer the partner that signed the contract. Victory shifts power into its hands, and with the rival faction gone there is no one left to balance it. This is a commitment problem in the sense of Powell (2006): the very shift in power that the alliance produces makes the original bargain renegotiable, and with no third party to enforce it the strengthened vassal has every reason to renege. The foreign's answer follows the logic of coalition formation in Acemoglu et al. (2008): rather than empower a single ally who will outgrow its leash, it keeps a balance of vassals so that no partner is ever strong enough to dictate terms after the fact. The commitment problem, not the cost of war, is what now pushes the conqueror away from the single strong client and toward parallel vassalage. These two ideas, the post-victory power shift and the balancing motive, are the core intuition of this section.

3.1 Formalism

Environment

We drop the assumption that a victorious faction abides by the indirect-rule contract. After winning the war with foreign help and ruling the whole territory alone, the winning faction D_i chooses to *Abide* by the agreed contract τ_i or to *Renegue*. Reneging triggers a fight between F and D_i , now with a consolidated military endowment $m'_i \geq m_i$, reflecting that D_i rules unopposed once the rival faction has been eliminated. The sequence is otherwise as in the benchmark.

Payoff structure

If D_i abides it keeps $1 - \tau_i$; if it reneges it fights F for the whole realm and earns $p(m'_i, m_f) - c_i$. So D_i abides only if

$$1 - \tau_i \geq p(m'_i, m_f) - c_i \iff \tau_i \leq \tau_i^B \equiv 1 - p(m'_i, m_f) + c_i.$$

The post-victory power shift makes τ_i^B the binding ceiling on what a single victorious vassal will tolerate, a ceiling absent in the benchmark.

Equilibrium

Because the consolidated vassal will renege on any tribute above τ_i^B , the foreign can no longer charge the single-vassal rate τ_i^R . Cutting the tribute down to τ_i^B to keep D_i loyal strips the single-vassal arrangement of its rents, and the foreign does better by buying off both factions and ruling through two vassals, neither of whom is ever left unopposed.

Proposition 3 (No commitment). *Assume the ratio contest success function and no commitment after victory. The foreign always proposes (τ_1^C, τ_2^C) , inducing both factions to cooperate and implementing indirect rule through two vassals.*

A balance of vassals is the foreign's commitment device. Keeping the two factions in place denies either one the unopposed consolidation that would let it renege, so the conqueror sacrifices the deeper extraction of a single client for the durability of a divided one. Where collection costs in Section 4.1 pulled the foreign toward one strong incumbent, the commitment problem pulls it back toward many.

4 Who collects? Working with the establishment and paying the accountants

With their exceptional military talent, the nomads were tasked to govern without their own bureaucrats. In some way, this is similar to the puzzle. But the usual practice of a nomad is to hop around the margins of a capital, efficiently demonstrate their military prowess, and go back home with a trade treaty. This section advances the argument that when human capital is limited and budget constraints are salient, Mongols and other nomads choose to ally with bureaucrats rather than optimize within the material structure.

4.1 Formalism

The model now puts a price on collection.

Environment

To collect the realm's taxes, the foreign must reach the whole country. A partner of share s_i already governs its own part; to tax the rest, the foreign must extend that partner's apparatus over the share it does not hold, $1 - s_i$, at a cost $f(1 - s_i)$, with f increasing

and $f(0) = 0$. A larger partner leaves a smaller gap and is cheaper to collect through. The foreign's own upkeep is a fixed cost it pays whomever it installs, so it cancels from the comparisons below. We study the single protectorate, where one local partner is built into the realm's tax collector, the form indirect rule took for a small conquest elite. Dual vassalage, where each faction taxes its own share, leaves no gap to cover and is set aside here. The question is which partner the foreign chooses: the incumbent, who already holds most of the realm, or the challenger, who does not.

Payoff structure

Ruling the whole polity through faction i pays the benchmark co-optation payoff net of the mobilization needed to reach the rest of the realm,

$$\Pi_i(s) = EU_F^{(i)} - f(1 - s_i),$$

so installing D_1 pays $EU_F^{(1)} - f(1 - s)$ and installing D_2 pays $EU_F^{(2)} - f(s)$. Mobilization is light for a large partner and heavy for a small one. To keep the boundary unique, assume mobilization is not too steep: $f'(1 - s) + f'(s) < 2p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)$.

Equilibrium

In the benchmark the foreign installs D_1 whenever its grievance advantage $EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)}$ is positive, which holds below a threshold $s^\dagger$. Take D_1 to be the militarily dominant faction, so $s^\dagger > \frac{1}{2}$ and the foreign already rules through D_1 over a stretch where D_1 is the majority incumbent, $(\frac{1}{2}, s^\dagger)$. Mobilization now rewards installing the larger partner, and the boundary moves out.

Proposition 4 (Collection costs widen incumbent rule). *Suppose $m_1 > m_2$, so the benchmark installs D_1 for $s \leq s^\dagger$ with $s^\dagger > \frac{1}{2}$. With collection costs the foreign installs D_1 for $s \leq s_\star^\dagger$, where $s_\star^\dagger$ is the unique solution of*

$$EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)} = f(1 - s) - f(s),$$

and $s_\star^\dagger > s^\dagger$. The range over which the foreign collaborates with the majority incumbent therefore widens from $(\frac{1}{2}, s^\dagger)$ to $(\frac{1}{2}, s_\star^\dagger)$, and it widens further as the mobilization cost f rises.

The logic is the one the Mongols faced. At the benchmark boundary the foreign is indifferent on grievance grounds between the two factions, but one of them, the incumbent, already governs most of the realm and is far cheaper to collect through, while the other would force the conqueror to build an apparatus across territory it never held. Collection costs break the tie toward the incumbent, and they keep breaking it across a stretch of shares

where grievance alone would have handed the realm to the challenger. The dearer collection is, the wider that stretch. Figure 3 shows the widened band.

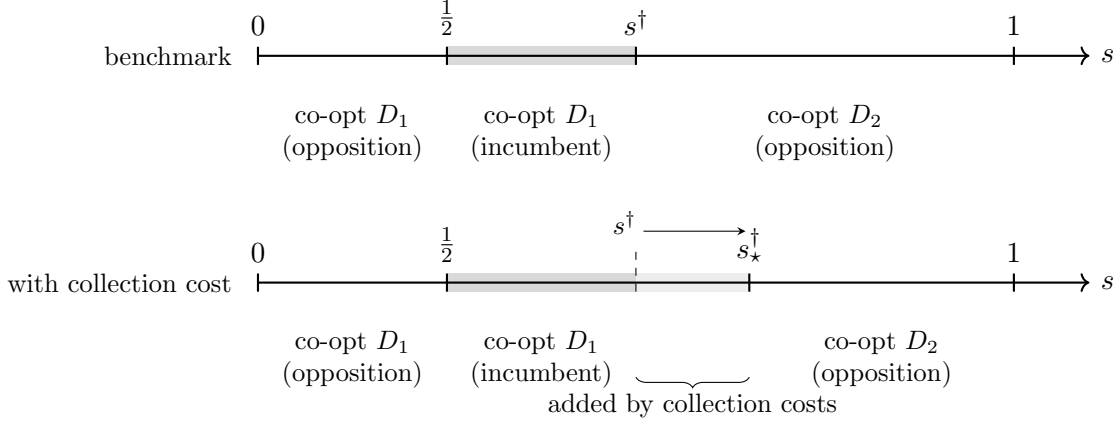


Figure 3: Which faction the foreign builds into the taxing vassal, benchmark versus the model with collection costs, when D_1 is militarily dominant ($s^\dagger > \frac{1}{2}$). Reaping taxes requires mobilizing $f(1 - s_i)$ to extend the chosen partner's reach over the rest of the realm, cheap for the incumbent and dear for the challenger. The boundary moves from $s^\dagger$ to $s_\star^\dagger > s^\dagger$, widening the range of collaboration with the majority incumbent to $(\frac{1}{2}, s_\star^\dagger)$.

5 Us vs them: to die for honor

It was hard to rationalize China's prolonged resistance against an overwhelmingly powerful Japanese conquest, if not for the unbreakable resolve for sovereignty and self-rule. In September 1931, Japan launched the Mukden Incident, which led to the occupation of northeastern China and the establishment of a puppet regime of Manchukuo. Outside of Manchukuo, however, various factions vied for control and brought widespread conflicts. The Nationalist government controlled by KMT, the Chinese Communist Party (CCP), and various regional warlords grappled with one another under a looming threat of Japanese aggression. By the end of 1936, the escalating conflict between KMT and CCP halted, and a united front against Japan emerged. When Japan started a full invasion of a more unified China in 1937, it quickly gained military success. The nationalist government led by Chiang Kai-shek began negotiating a reasonable surrender terms with Japan in 1938, which only led to the defection of its number two leader, Wang Ching-wei, to Japan. After two years of negotiation, Wang established a Japan-controlled regime that lasted until Japan surrendered to the Nationalist government in 1945.

KMT did seek help from Japan in the hope of a peaceful solution in 1938. Wang insisted that Chiang supported a more serious negotiation of Sino-Japanese peace with Japan than

Chiang claimed to be. Indeed, peace with Japan could help the KMT contain the rise of communists in the rural area. Neither Chiang nor Wang was completely blind to the higher chance of military success that communists could enjoy at the end of the war, and it is reasonable to conclude that KMT did seek serious cooperation with Japan. Almost immediately after Wang's defection, he started to realize that Tokyo was reluctant to seriously consider the terms he signed up for, such as a phased withdrawal of Japanese troops. His delegate's terms from the Chungkuang-tang Conference were seriously compromised by the time of his defection. On top of that, the anti-expansionists that did prefer a more lenient policy towards Wang and China, like Inukai and Kagesa, became increasingly irrelevant politically. He became much more aware of his status as a puppet when he was forced to recognize Manchukuo's independence, including over the southern part of the Great Wall. He relinquished most of the regime's decision-making power to Japanese officers.

Chiang's eventual dismissal of the Japanese offer and Wang's miserable fate as a puppet cannot be explained if not for the unanticipated resolution of nationalist sentiment in China against an overwhelmingly powerful Japanese force. As Boyle (1972) points out, it was unfathomable to Wang and Japan how deeply Chinese citizens remained committed to national self-rule and independence after Japan's sweeping victories from 1937 to 1938, as Japan initiated the doomed heping movement. Wang was shocked by how much brutality Chiang was ready to inflict on civilians for a meager victory against the Japanese troops in the Huayuankou incident and became determined that some peaceful arrangement just has to be better than this.

But Wang and Japan were wrong. Wang quickly fell from the status of a national hero to a traitor after initiating the heping (peace) campaign. And Chiang smartly steered away from the same fate. Wang famously "broke up" with Chiang via telegraph (yandian) and walked into the miserable failure of a regime. But the cause of bargaining failure is not a result of incomplete information. Had it been known that China was committed to resistance and that Japan harbored ambitions that warranted uniform assimilation across East Asia, bargaining failure would have been expedited. Nationalism and political alignment finally served as a coordinating device for the fractured factions, the CCP and the KMT, to set up a united front again, and the foreign robbery scheme failed.

5.1 Formalism

So far the factions differ only in military strength and in their share of the revenue. Empirically, imperial force also sorts partners along an ideological grain. A conqueror is seldom indifferent between a partner whose faith, ethnicity, or political program resembles its own

and one that does not, and neither is the target partner.

Environment

Let $d_i \geq 0$ be the ideological distance between the foreign power F and faction i . This introduction is quite straightforward mathematically in the sense that it just introduces a free-range parameter that could allow for proliferation of equilibrium behaviors. A faction that accepts co-optation must administer F 's program, and doing so across an ideological gulf carries a legitimacy cost d_i , borne by the faction whenever it serves as a vassal. A faction that resists pays nothing of the sort, since it collaborates with no one. Distance is otherwise inert: it leaves the contest, the war costs, and the shares untouched, and the benchmark is the special case $d_1 = d_2 = 0$. The sequence of moves is similar as above.

Payoff structure

Lemma 2. *Fix the strengths and shares. Relative to the benchmark, the collaboration costs lower the foreign power's payoff from each co-optation mode by the cost of whichever factions it installs:*

$$\widetilde{EU}_F^{(1)} = EU_F^{(1)} - d_1, \quad \widetilde{EU}_F^{(2)} = EU_F^{(2)} - d_2, \quad \widetilde{EU}_F^{dual} = EU_F^{dual} - d_1 - d_2,$$

while direct rule, $V_{direct} = p(m_f, m_1 + m_2)(1 - \kappa_D) - c_f$, and the status quo, 0, are unchanged.

Direct rule is the exception. There the foreign power brings in its own administrators rather than relying on a local faction, so no faction pays the cost d_i and the foreign power need not make up for it. This is the key difference that drives the rest of the section: co-optation carries the cost of ideological distance, conquest does not.

Equilibrium

Two things now change. Consider first which faction the foreign power picks, in a case where the benchmark co-opts only one. It compares $\widetilde{EU}_F^{(1)} = EU_F^{(1)} - d_1$ with $\widetilde{EU}_F^{(2)} = EU_F^{(2)} - d_2$, and keeps the benchmark partner only if that faction's lead in grievance is larger than the extra cost of its distance.

Proposition 5 (Alignment overrides grievance). *Let $\Delta \equiv EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)}$ be the benchmark grievance advantage of faction 1, and suppose $\Delta > 0$, so the benchmark co-opts faction 1. Under collaboration costs the foreign co-opts faction 1 if $d_1 - d_2 \leq \Delta$ and faction 2 if $d_1 - d_2 > \Delta$. The co-opted partner switches from the more aggrieved faction to the more aligned one exactly when the alignment gap $d_1 - d_2$ overtakes the grievance gap Δ .*

In the benchmark the foreign power chose its partner by grievance alone, the gap between a faction's military strength and its share, which is what lets the foreign power charge a high

tribute. Ideological distance now adds a second consideration. A faction can be the more profitable one to arm and still be passed over if it is too far from the foreign power in aims, just as a conqueror may turn down a willing but estranged challenger in favor of a more pliable partner that shares its religion or politics.

The second change is whether the foreign power enters this co-optation game at all. As both factions grow more distant, every co-optation payoff in Lemma 2 falls while the payoff from direct rule stays the same, so invasion, and then staying out, become attractive again. Write $\bar{d}_i \equiv EU_F^{(i)} - V_{\text{direct}}$ for the largest distance to faction i at which arming it alone is still better than ruling directly.

Proposition 6 (Misalignment reopens conquest and exit). *Hold strengths and shares fixed and vary (d_1, d_2) .*

- (i) *If $d_i \leq \bar{d}_i$ for at least one faction, the foreign co-opts, ruling indirectly through the faction that maximizes $EU_F^{(i)} - d_i$, or through both where the benchmark installs dual vassals.*
- (ii) *If $d_1 > \bar{d}_1$ and $d_2 > \bar{d}_2$ and $V_{\text{direct}} > 0$, the foreign invades and rules directly.*
- (iii) *If $d_1 > \bar{d}_1$ and $d_2 > \bar{d}_2$ and $V_{\text{direct}} < 0$, the foreign abstains.*

Proposition 2 said the foreign power always prefers co-optation to conquest. That held only because the benchmark assumed no ideological distance. Once ruling through a local partner is costly, co-optation loses its advantage wherever no faction is close enough, and the foreign power either brings in its own administration or, if the territory is not worth governing alone, stays out. The same single parameter therefore divides targets into three outcomes, indirect rule, direct rule, and staying out, with the lines between them set by how distant the available partners are. Figure 4 shows how the outcome changes as the two distances vary.

A Proofs

Proof of Lemma 1. If D_j cooperates, D_i compares accepting, worth $(1 - \tau_i)s_i$, against resisting, worth $p(m_i, m_f + m_j) - c_i$ (fighting the F - D_j coalition for its share). Acceptance is optimal iff $(1 - \tau_i)s_i \geq p(m_i, m_f + m_j) - c_i$, i.e. $\tau_i \leq \tau_i^C$. If D_j resists, accepting makes D_i part of the F - D_i coalition, worth $p(m_f + m_i, m_j)(1 - \tau_i) - c_i$, while resisting joins collective resistance worth $p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s_i - c_i$. Acceptance is optimal iff $p(m_f + m_i, m_j)(1 - \tau_i) \geq p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s_i$, i.e. $\tau_i \leq \tau_i^R$. $\square$

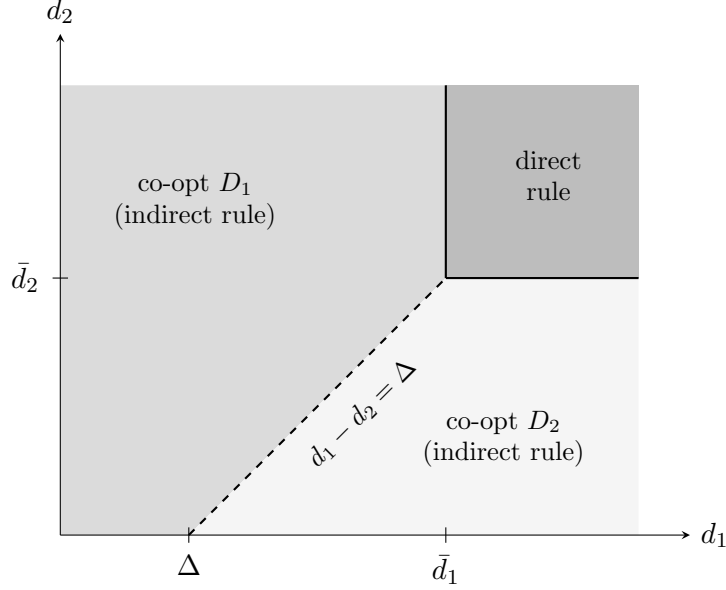


Figure 4: What the foreign power does as the two ideological distances (d_1, d_2) vary, for a case where the benchmark co-opts a single faction whose grievance lead is $\Delta = EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)} > 0$. The foreign power rules indirectly through the closer of the two factions until both are more distant than the cutoffs $\bar{d}_i = EU_F^{(i)} - V_{\text{direct}}$, beyond which it invades and rules directly. The diagonal $d_1 - d_2 = \Delta$ is the point where it switches partners (Proposition 5). If direct rule is not worthwhile ($V_{\text{direct}} < 0$), the upper-right region is staying out rather than direct rule.

Proof of Proposition 1. Under dual vassalage F maximizes $\tau_1 s + \tau_2(1 - s)$ subject to both acceptance constraints, so it sets (τ_1^C, τ_2^C) and obtains

$$EU_F^{\text{dual}} = \sum_{i=1,2} \left[1 - \frac{p(m_i, m_f + m_j) - c_i}{s_i} \right] s_i = 1 - p(m_1, m_f + m_2) - p(m_2, m_f + m_1) + c_1 + c_2 = p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) + c_1 + c_2,$$

using $p(m_i, m_f + m_j) = 1 - p(m_f + m_j, m_i)$ and additivity of the contest across the two engagements. Ruling through D_1 alone, F sets $\tau_1 = \tau_1^R$ (the most it can charge while D_1 still prefers alliance to resistance) and obtains

$$EU_F^{(1)} = p(m_f + m_1, m_2) \left[1 - \frac{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s}{p(m_f + m_1, m_2)} \right] - c_f = p(m_f + m_1, m_2) - p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s - c_f.$$

Comparing, $EU_F^{(1)} > EU_F^{\text{dual}}$ iff

$$p(m_f + m_1, m_2) - p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s - c_f > p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) + c_1 + c_2 \iff s < p(m_1, m_2) - \frac{c_f + c_1 + c_2}{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)} = \underline{s},$$

where the equivalence uses $p(m_f + m_1, m_2) - p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) = p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)p(m_1, m_2)$ along the contest's marginal-contribution identity. The symmetric computation for ruling

through D_2 gives the cutoff $\bar{s}$. Hence single-vassal rule through the aggrieved faction is optimal at the extremes and dual vassalage in the middle band. $\square$

Proof of Corollary 1. In the lower region $s < \underline{s}$ the foreign co-opts D_1 , whose share is s , so the co-opted faction is a minority for every such s iff $\underline{s} \leq \frac{1}{2}$. From the definition of $\underline{s}$,

$$\underline{s} \leq \frac{1}{2} \iff p(m_1, m_2) - \frac{1}{2} \leq \frac{c_f + c_1 + c_2}{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)}.$$

Under $p(x, y) = x/(x + y)$ we have $p(m_1, m_2) - \frac{1}{2} = \frac{m_1 - m_2}{2(m_1 + m_2)}$ and $1/p(m_1 + m_2, m_f) = \frac{m_1 + m_2 + m_f}{m_1 + m_2}$; multiplying the inequality through by $m_1 + m_2 > 0$ gives $m_1 - m_2 \leq 2(c_f + c_1 + c_2)(m_1 + m_2 + m_f)$. The upper region $s > \bar{s}$ co-opts D_2 , whose share is $1 - s$, a minority iff $s > \frac{1}{2}$; by the symmetric argument this holds throughout the region iff $\bar{s} \geq \frac{1}{2}$, i.e. $m_2 - m_1 \leq 2(c_f + c_1 + c_2)(m_1 + m_2 + m_f)$. Combining the two extremes gives the stated condition in $|m_1 - m_2|$, and equivalently in $|p(m_1, m_2) - \frac{1}{2}|$. If the gap exceeds the bound then $\underline{s} > \frac{1}{2}$ (or $\bar{s} < \frac{1}{2}$), and on $(\frac{1}{2}, \underline{s})$ the foreign co-opts D_1 while it holds the majority. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 2. Dual vassalage at (τ_1^C, τ_2^C) is always feasible and, by the proof of Proposition 1, yields F exactly $p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) + c_1 + c_2$. Since F optimizes over co-optation schedules, its optimal co-optation payoff is at least this. Invasion yields $p(m_f, m_1 + m_2)(1 - \kappa_D) - c_f = p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) - \kappa_D p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) - c_f$. Because $\kappa_D > 0$ and $c_f, c_1, c_2 > 0$,

$$p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) + c_1 + c_2 > p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) > p(m_f, m_1 + m_2)(1 - \kappa_D) - c_f,$$

so optimal co-optation strictly exceeds invasion for every s . F therefore never strictly prefers unilateral invasion. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 3. Given an agreed contract τ_i , if the victorious faction D_i abides it obtains $1 - \tau_i$, and if it reneges it obtains $p(m'_i, m_f) - c_i$; hence D_i abides iff $\tau_i \leq \tau_i^B \equiv$

$1 - p(m'_i, m_f) + c_i$. Compare this ceiling with the single-vassal rate τ_i^R :

$$\begin{aligned}
\tau_i^B - \tau_i^R &= \frac{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s_i}{p(m_f + m_i, m_j)} - p(m'_i, m_f) + c_i \\
&= \frac{m_1 + m_2}{m_f + m_i}s_i - \frac{m'_i}{m_f + m'_i} + c_i \\
&< \frac{m_1 + m_2}{m_f + m_i} \left[\frac{m_i}{m_1 + m_2} - \frac{c_f + c_1 + c_2}{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)} \right] - \frac{m'_i}{m_f + m'_i} + c_i \\
&= \frac{m_i}{m_f + m_i} - \frac{m'_i}{m_f + m'_i} + c_i - (c_f + c_1 + c_2) \left(1 + \frac{m_j}{m_f + m_i} \right) \\
&= \underbrace{\frac{m_i}{m_f + m_i} - \frac{m'_i}{m_f + m'_i}}_{\leq 0} - (c_f + c_j) \left(1 + \frac{m_j}{m_f + m_i} \right) - c_i \frac{m_j}{m_f + m_i} < 0,
\end{aligned}$$

where the first inequality uses $s_i < \frac{m_i}{m_1 + m_2} - \frac{c_f + c_1 + c_2}{p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)}$, the condition under which F would offer τ_i^R to induce D_i alone. Thus $\tau_i^B < \tau_i^R$: to forestall reneging the foreign must lower the tribute below the single-vassal rate. Offering τ_i^B yields

$$EU_F(\tau_i^B) = p(m_f + m_i, m_j)\tau_i^B - c_f = p(m_f + m_i, m_j)[p(m_f, m'_i) + c_i] - c_f,$$

which falls short of the two-vassal payoff $p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) + c_1 + c_2$, since the difference is

$$\begin{aligned}
&p(m_f + m_i, m_j)[p(m_f, m'_i) + c_i] - c_f - p(m_f, m_1 + m_2) - c_i - c_j \\
&= \frac{m_f + m_i}{m_1 + m_2 + m_f} \cdot \frac{m_f}{m'_i + m_f} - \frac{m_f}{m_1 + m_2 + m_f} - [1 - p(m_f + m_i, m_j)]c_i - c_j - c_f \\
&= \underbrace{\frac{m_f}{m_1 + m_2 + m_f} \cdot \left[\frac{m_i + m_f}{m'_i + m_f} - 1 \right]}_{\leq 0} - [1 - p(m_f + m_i, m_j)]c_i - c_j - c_f < 0.
\end{aligned}$$

Hence when post-victory consolidation is a concern, F strictly prefers two vassals and proposes (τ_1^C, τ_2^C) . $\square$

Proof of Proposition 4. The foreign installs D_1 rather than D_2 iff $\Pi_1(s) \geq \Pi_2(s)$, i.e. $EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)} \geq f(1-s) - f(s)$. Write $\Psi(s) \equiv [EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)}] - f(1-s) + f(s)$. From the benchmark payoffs,

$$EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)} = [p(m_f + m_1, m_2) - p(m_f + m_2, m_1)] + p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)(1 - 2s),$$

so $\frac{d}{ds}[EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)}] = -2p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)$ and $\Psi'(s) = -2p(m_1 + m_2, m_f) + f'(1-s) + f'(s) < 0$ by assumption. Hence Ψ is strictly decreasing with a unique zero $s_\star^\dagger$, and the foreign

installs D_1 iff $s \leq s_\star^\dagger$. The benchmark threshold $s^\dagger$ solves $EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)} = 0$, giving $s^\dagger = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{p(m_f + m_1, m_2) - p(m_f + m_2, m_1)}{2p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)} > \frac{1}{2}$ since $m_1 > m_2$ implies $p(m_f + m_1, m_2) > p(m_f + m_2, m_1)$. Evaluating, $\Psi(s^\dagger) = f(s^\dagger) - f(1 - s^\dagger) > 0$ because $s^\dagger > \frac{1}{2}$ gives $s^\dagger > 1 - s^\dagger$ and f is increasing. Since Ψ is strictly decreasing with $\Psi(s_\star^\dagger) = 0$, $\Psi(s^\dagger) > 0$ yields $s_\star^\dagger > s^\dagger$, so the foreign installs the majority incumbent D_1 on the widened range $(\frac{1}{2}, s_\star^\dagger) \supset (\frac{1}{2}, s^\dagger)$. Finally, replacing f by $f + \epsilon h$ with $h > 0$ increasing shifts Ψ by $\epsilon[h(s) - h(1 - s)]$, positive for $s > \frac{1}{2}$, so the zero moves right and $s_\star^\dagger$ rises with the level of the mobilization cost. $\square$

Proof of Lemma 2. A faction incurs d_i only when it accepts co-optation, so each acceptance threshold of Lemma 1 falls by that cost expressed in the relevant units. Against a cooperating rival, acceptance requires $(1 - \tau_i)s_i - d_i \geq p(m_i, m_f + m_j) - c_i$, i.e. $\tau_i \leq \tau_i^C - d_i/s_i$; against a resisting rival, $p(m_f + m_i, m_j)(1 - \tau_i) - d_i \geq p(m_1 + m_2, m_f)s_i$, i.e. $\tau_i \leq \tau_i^R - d_i/p(m_f + m_i, m_j)$. The foreign still charges the binding threshold. Ruling through D_1 alone it collects $p(m_f + m_1, m_2)[\tau_1^R - d_1/p(m_f + m_1, m_2)] - c_f = EU_F^{(1)} - d_1$; ruling through D_2 alone, $EU_F^{(2)} - d_2$ by the symmetric computation; installing dual vassals, $\sum_i (\tau_i^C - d_i/s_i)s_i = EU_F^{\text{dual}} - d_1 - d_2$. Direct rule installs no vassal and pays no d_i , so V_{direct} and the status-quo payoff 0 are unchanged. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 5. Where the benchmark co-opts a single faction, the foreign compares $\widetilde{EU}_F^{(1)} = EU_F^{(1)} - d_1$ and $\widetilde{EU}_F^{(2)} = EU_F^{(2)} - d_2$ from Lemma 2. It keeps faction 1 iff $EU_F^{(1)} - d_1 \geq EU_F^{(2)} - d_2$, i.e. $d_1 - d_2 \leq EU_F^{(1)} - EU_F^{(2)} = \Delta$, and switches to faction 2 otherwise. Since $\Delta > 0$, at $d_1 = d_2$ the foreign keeps faction 1; the switch occurs as $d_1 - d_2$ rises through Δ . $\square$

Proof of Proposition 6. By Lemma 2 the foreign's best co-optation payoff is

$$W(d) = \max\{EU_F^{(1)} - d_1, EU_F^{(2)} - d_2, EU_F^{\text{dual}} - d_1 - d_2\},$$

nonincreasing in each d_i , to be compared with the constants V_{direct} and 0. Since $EU_F^{\text{dual}} - d_1 - d_2 \leq EU_F^{(i)} - d_i$ whenever $EU_F^{\text{dual}} - EU_F^{(i)} \leq d_j$, dual vassalage is not the unique best co-optation mode once a partner is distant, and there $W(d) = \max_i\{EU_F^{(i)} - d_i\}$. Hence $W(d) \geq V_{\text{direct}}$ iff $EU_F^{(i)} - d_i \geq V_{\text{direct}}$ for some i , that is $d_i \leq \bar{d}_i$ for some i : region (i). If instead $d_1 > \bar{d}_1$ and $d_2 > \bar{d}_2$, then $W(d) < V_{\text{direct}}$ and co-optation is dominated; the foreign invades when $V_{\text{direct}} > 0$, region (ii), and abstains when $V_{\text{direct}} < 0$, region (iii). At $d_1 = d_2 = 0$, $W = EU_F^{\text{dual}} > V_{\text{direct}}$ by Proposition 2, so the origin lies in region (i); conquest and exit are reopened only by distance. $\square$

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